systems function. In the pages that follow, now updated and expanded for this second edition, readers will also discover something about the history of ecological concepts, the leading thinkers, and the different perspectives from which they approached the questions they sought to answer.

One thing that sets this book apart is the manner in which the rich, memorable, and attractive content is presented. A huge body of information and insight is effectively conveyed by clear layout, graphics, illustrations, and quotes, enabling readers to quickly achieve an understanding of many important ecological ideas and the people behind them: James Lovelock's Gaia hypothesis, Norman Myers's warnings about impending mass extinction, and Rachel Carson's work to expose the effects of toxic pesticides among them.

The diverse body of information found in the pages that follow could not be more important. For while the headlines and popular debate suggest it is politics, technology, and economics that are the vital forces shaping our common future, it is in the end ecology that is the most important context determining societies' prospects, and indeed the future of civilization itself. As ever more climate-related events unfold around us, the expanded coverage within this second edition helps the reader understand the latest developments, dangers, and possibilities within ecological science.

I hope you find *The Ecology Book* to be an enlightening overview of what is not only the most important subject, but also the most interesting.

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